A Look at Cyberbullying

1. What is it?

Cyberbullying is when someone uses social media, apps, or websites to hunt down, embarrass, or threaten another person on purpose. It’s different from the old-fashioned bullying you'd see on a playground because it doesn't stop when the school bell rings. It happens around the clock and can be seen by thousands of people in the blink of an eye.

2. A Real-Life Example: Amanda Todd

This case is a heartbreaking look at how online harassment can spiral out of control. It’s a well-known story that shows just how dangerous the internet can be.

• Phase 1: The Start. Things began when a predator tricked 12-year-old Amanda into sending a private, revealing photo over a webcam.

• Phase 2: Spreading the Image. About a year later, that person used the photo to build a fake Facebook page. They sent the picture to her family, her friends, and everyone she went to school with.

• Phase 3: The Pile-On. Amanda tried to switch schools to get away from the shame, but the harasser followed her. They kept re-posting the photo and encouraged other people to join in on the bullying.

• Phase 4: From Screen to Street. The hate didn't stay online. A group of kids, egged on by what they saw on the web, actually attacked her in person.

• Phase 5: Total Loneliness. Amanda eventually posted a video on YouTube asking for help. Instead of getting support, the bullying kept going until she felt like she had nobody left in her corner.

3. Who are the targets?

Usually, targets are students or young people who spend a lot of time online. They’re often picked on because of a perceived weakness or a mistake they made in the past.

4. The Result

In this case, the fallout was as bad as it gets. Amanda suffered from deep depression and anxiety. She pulled away from everyone, and because the bullying never let up, she eventually took her own life. It's a dark reminder that what people say and do online can have fatal results.

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Source: "The Amanda Todd Story," *The New Yorker*. Available at: https://www.newyorker.com/culture/culture-desk/amanda-todd-and-the-vicious-cycle-of-cyberbullying (Accessed 2026).